and Shahrukh's heads together and marching upon Samarqand, that was easier said than done.

When, in 1575, Sulaiman's hopes of regaining Badakhshan from Shahrukh with Akbar's help were stymied by Munim Khan's demise in Bengal, and the diversion of imperial troops to the east, the disappointed widower had begged leave to go on the Haj. Pilgrimage, however, was the last thing on the homesick warlord's mind: instead of Mecca, he went to Persia. Some four years later, having wrangled troops from the Persian shah, Sulaiman arrived in Kabul, seeking help from Akbar's half-brother this time. This was in 1579, when troubles in Bengal were brewing, and Hakim thought he might enlist the aid of his 'old and experienced'[6] uncle to exacerbate discontent in Hindustan. Sulaiman was too experienced to allow any such foolhardy meddling with Akbar's realm, however, and persuaded his nephew to march with him to Badakhshan instead.

Akbar wasn't pleased with the alliance. It was one thing for Sulaiman to ask Akbar for aid, entirely another to ally with Hakim. The emperor, too, was about to send troops to Badakhshan – to help Shahrukh, this time – when news of a truce between grandfather and grandson arrived.

The truce did not hold. It was such an abject failure, in fact, that far from establishing a peaceful joint command, the two squabbling lords of Badakhshan lost their kingdom to neighbouring Turan. Sulaiman and Shahrukh were ejected from the family seat; and, one by one, they would both seek shelter in Hindustan. Shahrukh came in 1584 and joined Akbar's court; Sulaiman, older and less willing to give up hope of his throne, arrived two years later, a vagabond in his old age, forced to retire his ambitions. He would spend three years in Lahore, where he died, aged seventy-seven. It is likely that the old warlord's last years, if comfortable, were tinged with an ache for home. Not for Sulaiman the global ambitions of his ancestors and relatives: the farthest he had ever ventured for conquest of his own was Kabul. He died, writes Abul Fazl, having spent his last days, 'in repose and enjoyment', but also, one imagines, in fretful melancholy.

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The monarch of Turan, who took Badakhshan from under Sulaiman's and Shahrukh's stubborn noses, was called Abdullah Khan. The Uzbek ruler